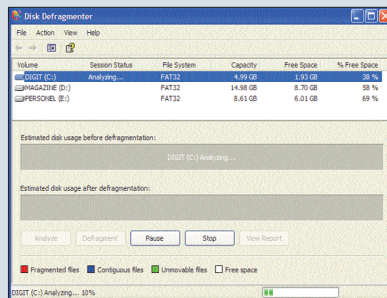


Organising files and folders

The number of files and folders stored on the hard drive increases as you keep installing programs. If the files are not properly organised, the performance of the hard drive degrades, and you will end up wasting valuable time, searching for files. The best way to keep a check on this is to partition the hard drive, and allocate the partition size, according to the number of applications that are going to be installed on the system, and the amount of data that will be stored. As far as storing files and folder goes, here are a few simple tips to follow:

- Always store your documents, and other working data, on the secondary partition.
- Name the folder based on the data to be stored in it. For example, store all account files in a folder named accounts.
- The file name should be such that it carries enough information regarding its content, the date it was created, etc. For example, Maxtor hard drive_august2003.doc
- Keep separate folders for different kind of files such as images, documents, and so on.
- Try not to install games, applications, and other system utilities on this partition, as it will clutter the disk with other kind of data, and hence affect disk access.

Over a period of time, as data gets stored and deleted, it becomes imperative to defrag the data. This entails re-arranging the data at one place for faster access. Windows itself provides you with this utility, so you need not bother installing a third party program. To access this program, go to **Start > Program > Accessories > System Tools > Disk Defragment**. The time required to complete the defragment task will depend upon the hard drive capacity. The other useful built-in option is Scandisk, which can also be found in the System tools. It checks the hard drive for errors such as lost clusters, bad sectors, and so on. Defrag once a month to keep the hard drive free from any errors.



Defragment your hard disk frequently for faster access to data

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some surprising results. The Maxtor MaxLine Plus II 250 GB hard drive, with an ATA-133 interface, gave the highest results, scoring a drive index of 39,680 KBps. This drive has an 8 MB memory buffer, which translates to better scores when you take into consideration the sequential read and write speed. The MaxLine Plus II gave excellent results in the sequential read and write speed test, with scores of 58 and 56 MBps. These scores were even better than that of any of the SATA drives. Similarly, the Barracuda ST3160021A drive from Seagate also gave some astonishing results by beating all the SATA drives in this particular test, and returned a drive index of 37,727 KBps, which was second best to the Maxtor 250 GB drive. Excellent drive electronics, and the 7,200 rpm spindle enabled this drive to give such an impressive performance. The only drive that could not make a good impact was the SV0602H drive from Samsung, being a 5,400 rpm hard drive.

Sadly, none of the SATA drives could live up to the expectations. The results were monotonous, with the scores deviating a little from each other. The drive index of all the SATA drives